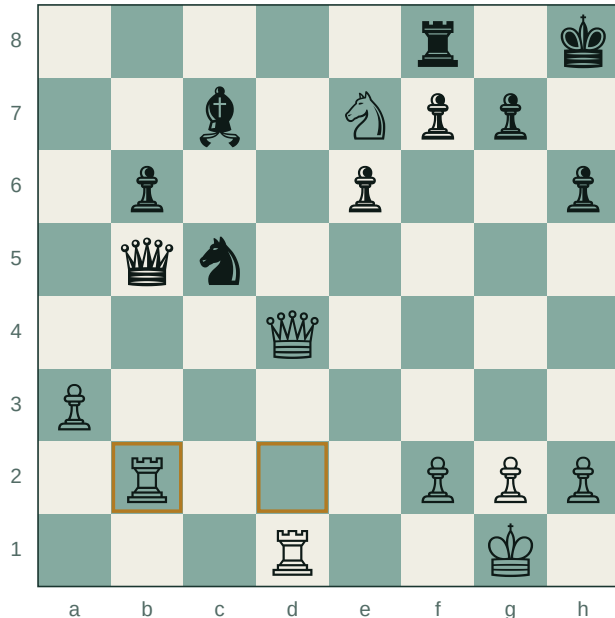


Trapping a piece: Black, move 26

Trapping a piece

Black to move



Previous move: 26.Rb2. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

26...Qe8 27. Nd5 exd5

26...Qe8 The queen moves from b5 to e8. Recorded reply: **27.Nd5**.

27...exd5 The pawn captures the knight on d5.

At the end, nominal material is White 23 / Black 25 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +3:** the balance goes from -1 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attacked piece is not trapped if it can give check, trade itself favorably, or open an escape through a sacrifice.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A trapped piece lacks safe retreat squares. Winning it usually requires restricting its routes before attacking it, or forcing it into a cage.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace every plausible escape square for the target, including captures and counterchecks. Then find the move that closes the remaining route.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: knight on e7. Check for tactical protection.